



BLKOUT CREATIVE LTD

Project Information Sheet

Making Ourselves From Scratch; The
Invitation — Croydon Loves You 2026

September 2026

Funded by Croydon Culture's Croydon Loves You 2026 Creative Health programme

What we're doing

Making Ourselves From Scratch brings eight Black queer men in Croydon to three workshops on one theme: invitation from a place. It culminates in a dinner they host on 28 December — Joseph Beam Day, named for the Black gay writer and activist who died in 1988 having told almost no one he was ill.

The arc: histories that go unspoken made visible, carried forward through storytelling, told in the men's own voices in a creative medium — an intervention that engages, and a process that builds relationships.

Each man chooses a Croydon place that carries our history — for example, streets connected to Ivor Cummings, a Black gay Home Office official and quiet organiser in London's mid-century Black community, or the Museum of Croydon — and writes from it. Derek Aidoo leads voice and dramatic monologue; each man writes and works a monologue of invitation, who he is asking, to what, why it matters, until he can hold a room, then records it.

Rob Berkeley leads a storytelling workshop: the story into a headline. The group builds a life-size magazine cover and the men photograph each other in it, under their own lines. Black queer men rarely see themselves on a cover; here they make one.

On 28 December they host the dinner, publish their recordings and take home their printed covers; every guest can step in too. Recordings and covers travel through January and February; in March they perform on a Croydon walk and talk, with the recordings forming its audio chapter.

Why we're doing this

79% of those joining our community hub came for connection, not information, not services. Isolation is the presenting issue, and it is structural. Black queer men are pushed out of Black spaces for being queer and out of queer spaces for being Black, and end up in neither. Our 2023–24 research found they also have little connection to the boroughs they live in, travelling across London for chosen community. This programme roots eight men in their own borough's ground.

The second is Joseph Beam, who wrote that Black men loving Black men is the revolutionary act, then died alone having told no one he was ill. Most wellbeing programmes flinch from the rage, or ask men to perform their pain for an audience. We do neither. We treat rage as valid, joy as a choice rather than a mood, and convening — the act of bringing your people together — as key to the revolution Beam was describing.

Working together weekly builds relationships that outlast the grant. Learning to hold a room with your own voice shifts self-esteem measurably. Handing participants the production of a real public event, rather than seats at one, is the difference between being served and being trusted.

How it runs

Three workshops at Croydon Voluntary Action's Waterside Centre, South Norwood, late October to November: two evenings and one Saturday afternoon.

- **Week 1** — with Derek Aidoo, each man chooses a Croydon place and writes a monologue of invitation from it, and its headline.
- **Week 2 (Saturday)** — the men build the booth together: a life-size front cover of the forthcoming BLKOUT magazine, then a storytelling workshop with Rob Berkeley.
- **Week 3** — with Derek, he works the monologue until he can hold a room with it, and records it. Then the men photograph each other in the cover, each under his own headline.

Monday 28 December, Joseph Beam Day: the men host Ivor's Table in the Living Room at Stanley Arts, eighteen covers rising with sales and donations, for the people they invited. The eight recordings are published that day, the eight covers are given, and the booth is open to every guest.

Key facts

Funder	Croydon Culture, Croydon Loves You 2026 Creative Health programme
Grant	Micro Grant, £1,500
Workshops	Late October–November 2026, CVA's Waterside Centre, South Norwood
Beam Day	Monday 28 December 2026, Stanley Arts, Living Room
Delivery window	Cannot start before mid-October 2026; delivered, evaluated and reported by 31 March 2027

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